

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Another Kind of Freedom
The God Who Sees Us

7 June 2026



"The Miracle of Light While Flying"
Gerardo Dottori, 1931

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on GATHER US IN and KINGSFOLD

Women Composers:

Rondeau in G minor (Elizabeth Jacquet de la Guerre)

Gigue in F Major (Elizabeth Turner)

Chorale in Bb Major (Fanny Mendelssohn Hensel)

Prelude in G minor (Clara Schumann)

Duo (Elizabeth von Herzogenberg)

As God Imagined (Brittney Elizabeth Boykin)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin & Dr. Ianthe Marini

Words of Gathering

Lulu Gregoropoulos & Garfield Morris Jr.

Today, in this place and time,
we reclaim ourselves as children of the Divine,
as we celebrate the beauty and worth of all creation.

This summer, as we embrace
another kind of freedom,
we are ever challenged to expand
our hearts and minds
to all we might experience and know
of the Divine, who is both holy and wild.

We believe in a God:
*who created each of us, who breathed into us our uniqueness,
who sees and delights in who we are, and what we can still become.*

We believe in the love of God:
*who laughs with us in our joy, who cries with us in our pain,
who yearns that all creation seek peace, reconciliation,
and love for each other.*

We believe in the justice of God:
*as revealed in sacred stories and texts
and through the life of Jesus,
and the lives of people
whose words and actions show them to be
holy prophets.*

*God created us; we are not alone.
God loves us; nothing will separate us from that love.
God frees us; we are free to love indeed!*

May it ever be so.
*May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and amen!*

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering** *Gather Us In*

Here in this place, the new light is streaming,
Shadows of doubt are vanished away.
See in this space our fears and our dreamings,
Brought here to you in the light of this day.
Gather us in, the lost and forsaken;
Gather us in; our spirits inflame.
Call to us now, and we shall awaken;
We shall arise at the sound of our name.

We are the young, our lives are a mystery;
We are the old, who yearn for your face.
We have been sung throughout all of history,
Called to be light to the whole human race.
Gather us in, the rich and the haughty;
Gather us in, the proud and the strong;
Give us a heart so meek and so lowly;
Give us the courage to enter the song.

Not just in buildings, small and confining,
Not in some heaven light years away,
Here in this place the new light is shining;
Now is God present, and now is the day.
Gather us in and hold us forever;
Gather us in and make us your own;
Gather us in, all peoples together,
Fire of love in our flesh and our bone.

***Prayer of Awareness**

O God Who Sees and Hears Us,
we thank you for your attentive presence in our lives.
When we feel invisible or overlooked,
remind us that you see us completely
and love us fully.

Emily Kang

Help us to rest in the knowledge that we are known by you.
Give us courage to see others as you see them,
that we might be part of making your seeing,
caring love visible in this world.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

Brave

SARA BAREILLES

Commonwealth Choir, Juniper Fayazova & Esme Gregoropoulos, *Soloists*, Brandon Harris, *Director*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Juniper Fayazova

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Max Bull & William Kang

We have gathered in this sacred place,
knowing every place is sacred
where we find peace and energy,
where beauty flourishes,
where we share our minds and our hearts.

So, today, let us celebrate
the richness and diversity of life
in the presentness of God,
through this greeting we now share.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition
from Genesis, chapter 16

Esme Gregoropoulos

For this witness of the ancients...
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Dr. Ianthe Marini

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Music For Reflection

Lullaby

PETER MAXWELL DAVIES

Esme Gregoropoulos, *Violin*, Lulu Gregoropoulos, *Cello*

Prayer of Our Hearts

Dr. Ianthe Marini & Emily Kang

We give thanks, Holy One, for the mystery of your
presence here with us.

We give thanks for the mystery of ourselves,
for the sense of compassion we have been given,
and for the things that are most precious in this life.

We give thanks that you are present everywhere God,
that you are visible through your love in each and every person.
May we use the gifts we have, imaginatively,
may we share them with one another,
and may we have the grace to use and share
everything we have, to bring healing
to this hurting world.

Holy One, you are the very breath we call life.
Help us as we breathe the air about us.
Help us to breathe it ever more deeply.

We lament the times we have placed limits
on the Spirit's work in us
by our lack of understanding,
by acting as if we were disconnected from our neighbor and the world,
by our deliberate words and actions that have ruptured connectedness,
and by our lack of understanding what living in community,
truly means.

Help us today to resolve our disconnection
and to move on with our lives,
in spite of whatever troubles or challenges
surround us.

May we feel Your inner strength,
Your courage,
Your resolve,

as we strive to shape our future lives
in ways that give dignity to them,
and help add dignity to others.

*We do this in response to the call we feel
to be co-creators of creation with you,
in this our time and our place.
This is our prayer.
Amen and Amen.*

Meditation Anthem

This is Me, from The Greatest Showman BENJ PASEK & JUSTIN PAUL
Commonwealth Choir, Lulu Gregoropoulos, Solo, Brandon Harris, Director

Sermon

The God Who Sees Us

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

William Kang

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

Unstoppable
Commonwealth Choir, Brandon Harris, Director

SIA

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Max Bull & Alizar Jmaya

Loving and Liberating God,
we have sensed the presence of the
Spirit of Life and Hope in this sacred time.

We have been awakened again to the mysteries that humble us,
the realities that orient us, and the community that sustains us -
in order that we may give ourselves in openness
to the expanding life before us.

*Bless now these gifts we share,
given in love and generosity,
that our church may continue
to be a place of light and grace,
in our cities, our countries, and in our world.
Amen and Amen.*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Emily Kang and Garfield Morris Jr.

May the God of Surprises delight you,
inviting you to accept gifts not yet imagined.

May the God of Transformation call you,
opening you to continual renewal.

May the God of Justice confront you,
daring you to see the world through God's eyes.

May the God of Abundance affirm you,
nudging you towards deeper trust.

May the God of Embrace hold you,
encircling you in the hearth of God's home.

May the God of Hopefulness bless you,
encouraging you with the fruits of faith.

May the God of Welcoming invite you,
drawing you nearer to the fullness of God's expression in you.

May God Who is Present be with you,
awakening you to God in all things, all people, and all moments.

May God forever be with you and free you.

Amen and Amen!

[Elizabeth Eiland Figueroa]

Choral Response

Staying Alive

THE BEE GEES

Commonwealth Choir, Esme Gregoropoulos, *Solo*, Brandon Harris, *Director*

*Hymn for the Journey

How Deep the Silence of the Soul

KINGSFOLD

How deep the silence of the soul that lives within your grace.
How full the gratitude of heart in your abiding place.
What rich serenity is found, what courage and release
When Wisdom teaches us to seek the gentle path to peace.

Like unseen chimes on moving air, like warm and morning sun,
Like glad-denying, green-ing, grow-ing things, like trees with blooms begun.
Such is your presence in our lives, you touch without a trace,
Until we turn and find ourselves held fast in your embrace.

-Lyrics by Sylvia Dunstan

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

As God Imagined - Reprise (Brittney Elizabeth Boykin)

Inside The Music

Brandon Harris, *Director of Commonwealth Choir*

"The youth of the Commonwealth were tasked with providing songs that they would like to sing today, based on the theme of being yourself, resilience, and confidence!

Sara Bareilles wrote the song "Brave" being inspired by a close friend who was struggling with coming out as Gay. This song is about finding the courage to speak YOUR truth even when you're afraid of how others may react. This song also encourages us to stop hiding the important parts of who we are and express who we are and who we want to become!

"This is Me" from the film *The Greatest Showman* is an anthem about self-acceptance, pride, and refusing to let other people's judgments define your worth. This song also acknowledges pain, rejection, and criticism, but the refusal to let those experiences break them. Instead, they make the choice to move forward.

"Unstoppable" by Sia explores the theme of projecting strength and determination in the face of challenge and adversity. This song describes someone who feels powerful, capable, and ready to overcome any and everything! This song also shows that true strength doesn't come from pretending to be perfect, but by accepting both our strength and our vulnerabilities and utilizing them to overcome all obstacles.

"Staying Alive" by The Bee Gees is presented today as a symbol of endurance—surviving and persevering no matter what life throws at you. This song also tells us that remaining true to ourselves, continuing through hardships, and believing in our abilities to endure we can keep moving forward regardless of the obstacles."